

Beyond the Classroom: Enhancing Nursing Education Through Exposure to Diverse Professional Experiences and Volunteering Opportunities

Sub-theme: Towards Excellence in Nursing Education

Ese Laureta Ekponbor, RN, RM, BNSc • Presented at the Inaugural CNMF West Africa Region Conference, Abuja, Nigeria • April 21–23, 2026

Introduction

Nursing education emphasizes classroom and clinical training, leaving graduate nurses with limited exposure to diverse professional experiences and volunteering opportunities. This gap can result in confusion about potential career paths, reduced competitiveness, and underdeveloped CVs for local and international opportunities. This study targets graduate nurses and aims to explore how engagement in volunteering and professional exposure during training can enhance career clarity, competitiveness, and prepare graduates for scholarships, employment, and diverse nursing roles. The objectives are to examine how volunteering and professional exposure improve graduates' competitiveness and CVs, determine the role of these experiences in clarifying career paths and reducing confusion, and highlight strategies educational institutions can adopt to integrate these experiences into the nursing curriculum.

Methods

A descriptive cross-sectional study was conducted among graduate nurses. Participants were recruited using convenience sampling, based on availability, and data was collected using a structured questionnaire. Participation was voluntary, and informed consent was obtained from all respondents. A total of 150 participants were included. Responses were analyzed using descriptive statistics, and results were presented using frequencies and percentages in tables.

Results

Analysis of the responses revealed that many participants reported that volunteering and professional exposure improved their career clarity, enhanced their CVs, and contributed to their professional skills such as adaptability, teamwork, and understanding of roles beyond clinical practice.

Conclusion

These experiences were perceived as valuable in preparing graduate nurses for career success and should be included in the nursing curriculum.